

1782



Chakri Mahaprasad Hall in Bangkok was built under Rama I.

WHILE THE VICTORIOUS FORMER COLONIES OF NORTH AMERICA

entered into complicated and protracted negotiations with Britain over their official recognition and their future, **Ireland** found that it was also in a position to receive a **new political settlement** from the British government. The Declaratory Act of 1720 and Poynings' Law of 1494 were repealed. These laws had been designed to place Ireland under the rule of the English Parliament. With many of the restrictions in these Acts lifted, Ireland was able to establish some degree of **legislative independence**. Despite the new freedoms, however, political participation was only open to **Protestants**, and the unrest this arrangement eventually prompted in the largely Catholic territory meant that self-rule had a short life span.

In **Siam (Thailand)**, a new ruling dynasty was established—the **Chakri**—after a power struggle following the demise of the previous ruler, **King Taksin**, who had left no heir. The Chakri remains Thailand's ruling house. It was established by **Rama I** (1737–1809), who had been the chief commander in the army and had won loyal support fighting against the Burmese. Rama I spent much of his reign on the **reconstruction of Siam** after years of warfare, building extensively, including a royal palace and Buddhist temples, though he remained a strong military leader, and repelled five further invasions from Burma.

1783



This bronze frieze depicts the signing of the Treaty of Paris in 1783, in which Britain recognized the independence of its former American colonies.

NEARLY TWO YEARS AFTER THE SURRENDER at Yorktown, the

Treaty of Paris, which formally ended the **Revolutionary War**, was finally signed on September 3 between Britain and its former American colony, calling for them to “forget all past misunderstanding and differences.” The document gave formal recognition to the United States and established the boundaries of the 13 states that it comprised. Although the settlement saw the establishment of the United States, there was still a significant European presence, with Spain holding large territories to the west.

Another treaty was signed between Britain, France, and Spain, in which Britain surrendered **Tobago** and **Senegal** to France and agreed to Spain

KEY

- Western Territory
- United States

States of the Union

This map shows the 13 original United States as recognized by the Treaty of Paris. US borders were extended to the Mississippi River under the treaty.



retaining **Minorca**—which it had regained the year before—and its territories in **Florida**.

In a small village called Annonay, in the southeast of France, two brothers were about to make



aviation history. On June 4, **Joseph** (1740–1810) and **Etienne Montgolfier** (1745–99) had the first public trial of a **hot air balloon** officially recorded. Only a couple of months later, and after some design modifications, they gave a demonstration of their balloon in front of Louis XVI and Marie Antoinette at Versailles. In the September 19 flight—one of several flights made in 1783—they put a sheep, a duck, and a rooster in the balloon's basket to see how the animals would fare at a high altitude. The first manned free flight, when the balloon was not tethered to the ground, took place on November 21 of the same year.

Balloon ride

This engraving shows a later Montgolfier balloon, named **Le Flesselles**, ascending over Lyon with seven passengers, on January 19, 1784. One of those on board was **Joseph Montgolfier**.

1784



A cartoon depicts the political implications of the India Act.

BECAUSE THE BRITISH PRESENCE

IN INDIA had evolved through the East India Company (EIC), the 18th century saw a growing tension between the EIC and the British government. The **India Act 1773** had already brought the company under tighter control, but its demands for government money to cover the cost of its many battles had prompted further action. The **India Act 1784**, which was ushered in under the government of British prime minister **William Pitt the Younger** (1759–1806), placed the EIC under even more scrutiny by establishing a Board of Control to look after civil, military, and

“EVERY RUPEE OF PROFIT MADE BY AN ENGLISHMAN IS LOST FOR EVER TO INDIA.”

Edmund Burke, British politician, on the East India Company, 1783

financial affairs, which would include members of the British government. The Act also stipulated that trade and territorial rule were to be two separate activities. Legislation that followed in the 19th century went even further, abolishing the EIC's monopoly and opening up trade, as well as allowing the settlement of Christian missionaries in the region.

February 3 Britain surrenders Caribbean island of St. Kitt's to France

February 5 Spain regains Minorca from Britain

February 5–March 28 Calabrian earthquakes in southern Italy wreak destruction and kill thousands

June 8 Laki volcano erupts in Iceland, causing widespread famine across Europe

September 3 Treaty of Paris signed, Britain recognizes Independent United States

December William Pitt “The Younger” (1759–1806) becomes British prime minister (to 1801)

Pitt's India Act puts more government control on East India Company

British Loyalist settlement founded at New Brunswick, Canada

Rama I (r.1782–1809) of Siam founds a new dynasty, with the capital in Bangkok

Ireland gains legislative independence

April 8 Russian Empire annexes Crimea

November 21 First manned hot air balloon flight by Montgolfier brothers in Paris

Spanish crown authorizes a botanical expedition to South America

December 13 Samuel Johnson, English poet and essayist, dies (b.1709)